

Incident Post-mortem Example

Title:

Use a descriptive title, such as "Service XYZ failed, affecting customers in the ABC region."

Incident date:

Post-mortem coordinator:

This is sometimes referred to as the 'owner' of the post-mortem process.

Post-mortem committee:

List of people that will be involved in the post-mortem. You may also include a review committee – a group of people whose job is to review the post-mortem report and recommend any changes before it is completed.

Summary of the event:

Write a summary of the incident in a few sentences. Include what happened, why, the severity of the incident and how long the impact lasted.

Supporting data:

Any graphs, tables, or other data that were used to analyse the attack.

Timeline of the attack and response:

This should be as detailed as possible. Include any lead-up events, the start of activity, the first known impact, and escalations. Also note any decisions that were made, and when the incident ended, along with any important post-impact events.

Separate categories can also be used, for example:

- **Detection** – when did the team detect the incident? How did they know it was happening? How could we improve time-to-detection? Consider: How would we have cut that time by half?
- **Response** – who responded to the incident? When did they respond, and what did they do? Note any delays or obstacles to responding.
- **Recovery** – describe how the service was restored and the incident was deemed over. Detail how the service was successfully restored and how you knew what steps you needed to take to recovery.

Impact

Describe how the incident impacted internal and external users during the incident. Include how many support cases were raised.

Incident Response Analysis:

Here are some examples of questions you could ask or address in this section:

- Was the event detected within the expected time?
- How was it detected? (e.g. alarm, customer ticket)
- How could time to detection be improved?
- Did the escalation work appropriately?
- Would earlier escalation have reduced or prevented the event?
- How did you know how to mitigate the event?
- How could time to mitigation be improved?
- How did you confirm the event was entirely mitigated (e.g. through testing, etc.)

Post-Incident Analysis:

Here are some examples of questions you could ask or address in this section:

- How were the contributing factors diagnosed?
- How could time to diagnosis be improved?
- Did you have an actual backlog item that could have prevented or reduced the impact of this event? If yes, why was this item not done?
- Could a programmatic verification rule (e.g. AWS Config) be used to prevent this event?
- Did a change trigger this event? If so, was this tested in an isolated environment? If yes, why did this pass through? Could more tests have prevented or reduced the impact of this event? If this change was manual, was there a playbook? Was that playbook practised, tested, and reviewed recently?
- Did a specific tool/command trigger the event? Could safeguards have prevented or reduced the impact of this event? Was there any safeguard triggered? If not, why were none in place?
- Could testing have prevented or reduced the impact of the event?

Continued..

Lessons Learned/Suggestions:

Describe what your team has learned and any suggestions they have for preventing similar events. Here are some examples of questions you could ask or address in this section:

- What did you learn that will help you in the future to prevent similar events?
- What unexpected things happened?
- What process broke down?

Any suggestions for improvements should be detailed and include who will be carrying them out, estimated cost and time involved, and whether they are a priority.